

Φωκυλίδης ὁ Μιλήσιος

Phocylides of Miletus on the City and Moral Life

eul_aid: bdg

Period: Ἀρχαϊκή [Archaic](#)
Dialect: Ἰωνική Ἑλεγειακή [Ionic Elegiac](#)
Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)
Format: Ἑμμετρος [Verse](#)

Phocylides of Miletus was a gnomic poet from Miletus in Ionia, active in the mid-6th century BCE and a contemporary of Theognis. His life coincided with the intellectual flourishing of Miletus, home to early philosophers like Thales. The social context of his poetry indicates he addressed the values and conduct of the citizenry within the polis.

His authentic work survives only in fragments, consisting of short maxims composed in Ionic elegiac couplets, many beginning with the phrase "and this too of Phocylides." These fragments offer practical ethical and domestic advice. A separate, spurious work is the Pseudepigraphic Poem of Phocylides, a 230-line hexameter poem from the Hellenistic or early Imperial period that presents Jewish ethical teachings under his name.

Phocylides is a key representative of archaic gnomic poetry, promoting traditional Greek values of moderation and practical wisdom. His authentic fragments were quoted by authors like Aristotle. His later fame, particularly among Christian writers, stemmed largely from the misattributed Pseudepigraphic Poem, which was admired for its apparent consonance with biblical morality.

Works (2)

- Ἐπίγραμμα · [Epigram](#) · 4 passages
- Γνώμαι · [Sentences](#) · 44 passages